only allowed to be present as the 11-year-old younger brother who happened to be around. My friends were never invited to play, and my role was strictly limited to carrying drinks, fielding and, just maybe, to bat at the end of the day.

'You can continue fielding,' Gerrit said.

'OK, thanks,' I replied.

I understood my place, and scurried away to field on the square-leg boundary at Div Park, as we called the cricket ground we had created out of our garden, no longer wearing the Jonty cap.

This incident is as clear in my mind as if it happened yesterday. It was conducted in jest, of course – Gerrit Deist was and remains a great friend to me and my brothers – but it does reflect the uncompromising environment in which I learned to play the game. Ever since those days, I have been primarily motivated by the challenge of proving myself worthy ... worthy of just playing, worthy of being respected by the opposition.

In my mind, respect is never earned by a natural ability to hit the ball or field well. Respect is only ever earned by being a fighter. That's what I wanted to be. I wanted to be known as a fighter. There have been thousands of talented players, but there are only a handful of real fighters, and I wanted to be one of them.

This particular game of garden cricket ran well into the afternoon and evening, and I fielded and fielded and fielded until, as the sun was setting, I heard the words I had been waiting all day to hear.

'OK, AB, you can bat now.'

This was my chance. Gerrit was bowling. He paced out his run-up as far as he could go, right back into the rose bed. It had been a long day. Everyone wanted to get me out quickly. I had other plans.

Even now, whenever I'm asked to name the best bowler I have ever faced, the answer that springs most quickly to mind is Gerrit Deist. That's not the response I give in media interviews because it would need to be followed by a lengthy explanation but it's the truth. We later played